

□ Reflection 2 □

The Mountain Has Many Paths : ఒకే శిఖరానికి అనేక మార్గాలు

On the Gītā's own stance toward different paths to the Divine

A note to the reader. This reflection cites only the Bhagavad Gītā itself. No other scriptures, traditions, or commentators are used to make the argument. The question is a narrow one: does the Gītā, read on its own terms in its own Sanskrit, support the idea that one path to the Divine is correct and others are wrong? The verses are allowed to answer for themselves.

The question

If the Gītā were truly the foundational text of a sectarian religion — one path competing with others for the title of "the true way" — we should be able to find, somewhere in its 700 verses, the moment when it says so. The moment when it warns its reader: follow this teaching and no other; the other gods are false; the other rituals are empty; those outside this fold are outside the truth.

No such verse exists.

This is, on first hearing, surprising. The Gītā is often read — and translated, and taught, and quoted — as if it were such a text. But the verses themselves go in the opposite direction. They acknowledge the diversity of human paths, they affirm that diverse paths reach the same Divine, and at the end they release even the Gītā's own teaching into the freedom of the seeker. This reflection is simply a catalogue of those verses, allowed to speak in their own order.

The first hint — BG 4.11

Early in the Gītā, in the chapter on the eternal recurrence of dharma, Kṛṣṇa makes a statement so direct and so generous that it has been almost completely ignored in later sectarian readings:

BG 4.11

ये यथा मां प्रपद्यन्ते तांस्तथैव भजाम्यहम् ।
मम वर्त्मानुवर्तन्ते मनुष्याः पार्थ सर्वशः ॥

ye yathā māṁ prapadyante tāṁs tathaiṣa bhajāmy aham |
mama vartmānuvartante manuṣyāḥ pārtha sarvaśaḥ ||

**"In whatever way people approach Me, in that very way do I receive them.
All people, O Pārtha, follow My path — in every way."**

The Sanskrit phrase sarvaśaḥ — "in every way," "by all means," "in all manners" — closes any door that an exclusivist reading might try to keep open. All people, by all paths, are following the Divine's own way.

Notice what this verse does not say. It does not say "all paths are equally valid" — which would be a modern relativist gloss. It says something more interesting: that the Divine itself *receives each seeker in the form in which the seeker approaches*. A person who approaches with awe meets awe; a person who approaches with love meets love; a person who approaches with philosophical inquiry meets the philosopher's God. The verse describes a Divine that is, by its nature, responsive to the shape of human longing — not a Divine that demands the longing take one prescribed form before being heard.

This is, already, a remarkable thing for any wisdom text to say in its own founder's voice. But the Gītā goes further.

The startling concession — BG 7.20–23

In Chapter 7, Kṛṣṇa addresses directly the question of people whose worship is not aimed at Him at all — at "other gods" (*anya-devatāḥ*). What the verses say about them is, by the standards of most exclusivist religious texts, astonishing:

BG 7.21–22 (paraphrased close to original)

yo yo yām yām tanuṁ bhaktaḥ śraddhayārcitum icchati |
tasya tasyācalāṁ śraddhāṁ tām eva vidadhāmy aham ||
sa tayā śraddhayā yuktas tasyārādhanam īhate |
labhate ca tataḥ kāmān mayaiḥ vihitān hi tām ||

**"Whatever form a devotee wishes to worship with faith —
in *that* form, I make their faith firm.
Endowed with that faith, they pursue worship in that form;
and from that, they obtain their desires — which are, in truth, granted by Me alone."**

In other words: even when a person worships what they take to be another god, the response and the reward come from the same source. The form of worship may differ; the underlying reality being worshipped, and the source of the answering grace, is one.

The Sanskrit is explicit: *yo yo yām yām tanum* — "whoever, whatever form." This is not a verse for "members of the in-group" only. It is a verse about the universality of sincere worship. Kṛṣṇa here is not condemning those who worship in forms other than His. He is saying that *He Himself is the one who stabilizes their faith, in whichever form it has taken, and that the response to their worship comes from Him whether or not they know His name.*

This is reaffirmed even more forcefully in Chapter 9:

BG 9.23

येऽप्यन्यदेवताभक्ता यजन्ते श्रद्धयान्विताः ।
तेऽपि मामेव कौन्तेय यजन्त्यविधिपूर्वकम् ॥

ye 'py anya-devatā-bhaktā yajante śraddhayānvitāḥ |
te 'pi mām eva kaunteya yajanty avidhi-pūrvakam ||

"Even those who are devotees of other gods, who worship them with faith — they too, O Kaunteya, are worshipping Me alone, though not in the prescribed manner."

The critique embedded here — avidhi-pūrvakam, "not in the prescribed manner" — is technical, not condemnatory. It says the method is less direct, perhaps less efficient. It does not say the worship is false, or that the worshippers are outside the Divine's care. Te 'pi mām eva — "they too, Me alone" — is unambiguous.

The universal anatomy of faith — BG 17.3

In Chapter 17, the Gītā takes a step that very few religious texts ever take: it offers a *universal* theory of faith — one that applies to *every* human being, irrespective of which tradition or path they happen to follow.

BG 17.3

सत्त्वानुरूपा सर्वस्य श्रद्धा भवति भारत ।
श्रद्धामयोऽयं पुरुषो यो यच्छ्रद्धः स एव सः ॥

sattvānūrūpā sarvasya śraddhā bhavati bhārata |
śraddhā-mayo 'yam puruṣo yo yac-chraddhaḥ sa eva saḥ ||

**"The faith of each person, O Bhārata, is according to their inner nature.
A human being is made of faith.
As is their faith, so are they."**

The first word, sattva-anurūpā, says: according to one's inner essence. The faith one ends up with is not arbitrary; it reflects who one already is. The closing phrase — yo yac-chraddhaḥ sa eva saḥ, "as is one's faith, so is one" — is one of the most quoted in Indian psychology. A person is built out of what they trust in. Change what you trust, and you change who you are.

Notice what this verse implies. The Gītā does not divide humanity into "the faithful" and "the faithless." It assumes *everyone* has faith — including (in modern terms) the atheist, whose faith is in the absence of God; including the materialist, whose faith is in matter; including the cynic, whose faith is in cynicism. Faith, in the Gītā's analysis, is not a religious commodity. It is simply *what one's inner life is built out of*. And the only meaningful question about it is: *what is the quality of yours?* Is it grounded in truth (sāttvika), in restless craving (rājasika), or in confusion and self-harm (tāmasika)?

This is a universal anatomy. It does not require the reader to be Hindu, or Indian, or theistic, or anything in particular. It simply names the human structure: *every person is made of faith; that faith determines who they become; you can examine yours, and you can change it.*

The dissolution of even the Gītā's own categories — BG 18.66

But the most surprising verse — and the one that most decisively settles the question of whether the Gītā is a sectarian text — comes at the very end. It is the famous *charama-śloka*, the "supreme verse," that Vaiṣṇava traditions hold to be the entire teaching of the Gītā in a single line:

BG 18.66

सर्वधर्मान्परित्यज्य मामेकं शरणं ब्रज ।
अहं त्वा सर्वपापेभ्यो मोक्षयिष्यामि मा शुचः ॥

sarva-dharmān parityajya mām ekaṁ śaraṇam vraja |
ahaṁ tvām sarva-pāpebhyo mokṣayiṣyāmi mā śucaḥ ||

**"Abandoning all dharmas, take refuge in Me alone.
I shall liberate you from all that binds you.
Do not grieve."**

Read carefully. The Sanskrit is unambiguous: *sarva-dharmān* — **all** dharmas. **Plural**.

If *dharma* meant "religion," this verse would mean "*abandon all religions*" — which would be an extraordinary thing for a supposed religious founder to say in the climactic teaching of his text. The verse becomes coherent only if *dharma* retains its original meaning: *all the various callings, duties, roles, identities, obligations, and self-prescribed paths by which you have been holding yourself together* — release the whole knot of them. Lay them down. The thing that liberates is not adherence to any one path, however excellent. It is the deeper surrender that releases attachment to *every* path, and trusts the Divine directly.

The Gītā's stance, in summary

Set out plainly, the verses give a consistent picture:

- **4.11** — The Divine receives every seeker in the form in which the seeker approaches; all people, by all paths, are walking the Divine's way.
- **7.21–22** — Whatever form a devotee chooses to worship, the Divine itself stabilizes that faith and grants the response.
- **9.23** — Even those who worship "other gods" with sincere faith are worshipping the one Divine, though less directly.
- **17.3** — Every human being is made of faith; the diversity of faiths is the diversity of inner natures, and the only meaningful question is the quality, not the brand.
- **18.66** — The final teaching is not "*adhere to this dharma above all others*" but "*abandon all dharmas and take direct refuge*" — a release from all sectarian identifications, including any that might have attached themselves to the Gītā's own teaching.

These five verses — and there are others in the same direction (notably 6.30, 13.27, 11.55, and the closing prayer of Chapter 18) — do not describe a religion. They describe a Divine that meets every honest seeker, in every honest path, and that calls the most mature seekers not to defend their path but to release it.

What this is not saying

Because these conclusions can be easily caricatured, it is worth saying clearly what this reflection is *not* claiming.

It is not claiming that all religions are the same. They are not. The traditions of the world disagree on many specifics, sometimes profoundly. Erasing those differences would be its own form of disrespect — to the traditions, to their adherents, and to the centuries of careful thought that produced them. The Gītā does not say all paths are identical; it says the Divine receives sincere seekers on whichever path they happen to be walking.

It is not claiming that doctrines do not matter. They do. What one believes shapes how one acts; how one acts shapes who one becomes; who one becomes determines whether one finds peace. The Gītā has very strong views about which inner attitudes are liberating and which are binding. It is precise about these. It simply does not organize those views as "*the right tribe vs. the wrong tribe*."

It is not claiming that the Gītā has no preferences. It does. It prefers the wise to the foolish, the disciplined to the impulsive, the compassionate to the cruel, the patient to the restless. It has detailed teachings about which qualities mature a person and which deform them. But these preferences cut *across* traditions, not *along* them. A patient and compassionate person of any background is closer to the Gītā's ideal than an impatient and cruel one of any background, including the one the Gītā emerged from.

It is not claiming that conversion or non-conversion is the issue. The Gītā is silent on the matter of switching one's identified path. It addresses something deeper: the inner quality of whatever path a person is on. A person walking sincerely on a path very different from the Gītā's idiom is, in the Gītā's own framework, walking sincerely toward the Divine. A person walking superficially on the Gītā's own path is, in the same framework, not.

What is being recovered

What is being recovered is something simple and, on reflection, obvious: a wisdom text from twenty-three centuries ago does not contain modern sectarian boundaries because the framework that produces such boundaries did not yet exist. The Gītā cannot be a tribal manifesto because it does not yet know what a tribe-defined-by-belief is. It can only do what wisdom literature actually does: ask the seeker who is reading it to look honestly at themselves, to do the work that is theirs to do, to surrender what cannot be controlled, and to trust the deeper reality that — by whatever name — has been receiving the human heart for as long as the heart has been reaching.

If the Gītā has a stance toward "other paths," it is this: there are no other paths. Every honest path is the Divine's own. Every honest seeker is already received. The mountain is one; the trails are many; the summit is not in dispute.

The inward turn

It would be easy, after a reflection like this one, to feel that one has scored a point against some imagined opponent — the sectarian, the exclusivist, the fundamentalist of one tradition or another. That feeling is precisely what the reflection is meant to resist.

The Gītā does not invite the reader to congratulate themselves on having a more inclusive theology than someone else. It invites the reader to look inward, and to ask whether *their own* heart has, perhaps without noticing, divided humanity into *us* and *them* on some axis or other — religious, national, ideological, partisan, generational, tribal in some subtler form than the obvious ones. The verses we have just read do not solve that question for anyone. They only return it to the reader.

The mountain has many paths, the Gītā says. The honest question is not *which path are the others on?* The honest question is *am I walking mine?*

The third and final reflection takes a step further, looking at the cycle of voices — across many cultures and many centuries — in which the same teaching has been spoken in many languages. That is the broader meaning

of *yadā yadā hi dharmasya*: not a Hindu doctrine of divine descent, but a description of how truth actually behaves in history.

— the writer, with humility and gratitude.

← Reflection 1: What Dharma Is Not · Reflection 3: Yadā Yadā →

☐ ☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐ ☐ · Reflection 2 — The Mountain Has Many Paths · Page 3 of 3 · END